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# Radical Right Populism and the Politics of Cruelty: The Case of COVID-19 in Brazil Under President Bolsonaro

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In this article, we explore cruelty under populism, focusing on radical right populism. We develop our argument by introducing a two-dimensional model of cruel behavior in politics, in which cruelty is conceptualized as a dependent variable defined in terms of empathy (how the leader addresses those who suffer) and action (how the leader acts to alleviate suffering). This framework provides a nuanced understanding of how cruelty and populism connect, providing an original and cutting-edge contribution to both bodies of work. We use our two-dimensional model of cruel behavior to shed light on the different ways radical right populists (RRP) embrace cruelty as part of their political strategies. We have come to three "ideal" types of RRP cruel behavior: downplaying, blaming, and conspiring. In order to advance our ideas, we rely on the qualitative analysis of Brazil's far-right populist President Jair Bolsonaro and his (in)actions regarding COVID-19, who once asked about the soaring number of dead from COVID-19 simply answered: "So what? What do you want me to do?." Using this case study, we empirically illustrate different ways in which how cruelty can manifest itself in practice and what real-life consequences it can have.

En este artículo, analizamos la crueldad en el populismo, centrándonos en el populismo de la derecha radical. Desarrollamos nuestro argumento presentando un modelo bidimensional del comportamiento cruel en la política, en el cual la crueldad se conceptualiza como una variable dependiente que se define en los términos de empatía (la manera en que el líder se dirige a aquellos que sufren) y acción (cómo actúa el líder para aliviar el sufrimiento). Este marco brinda un entendimiento variado de cómo se relacionan la crueldad y el populismo, y ofrece una contribución original e innovadora a ambas obras. Utilizamos nuestro modelo bidimensional del comportamiento cruel para aclarar las diferentes maneras en que los populistas de la derecha radical adoptan la crueldad como parte de sus estrategias políticas. Hemos llegado a tres tipos "ideales" de comportamientos crueles del populismo de la derecha radical: restar importancia, culpar y conspirar. Para presentar nuestras ideas, dependemos del análisis cualitativo del presidente populista de extrema derecha de Brasil, Jair Bolsonaro, y sus (in)acciones en torno a la COVID-19, quien una vez, como respuesta al número exorbitante de muertes por esta enfermedad, simplemente dijo: "¿Y qué? ¿Qué quieren qué haga?". Utilizando este estudio de caso, ilustramos de forma empírica las diferentes maneras en que la crueldad puede manifestarse en la práctica y qué consecuencias puede tener en la vida real.

Dans cet article, nous explorons la cruauté sous le populisme en nous concentrant sur le populisme d'extrême droite. Nous développons notre argument en introduisant un modèle bidimensionnel du comportement cruel en politique dans lequel la cruauté est conceptualisée en tant que variable dépendante définie en termes d'empathie (la manière dont le dirigeant traite ceux qui souffrent) et d'action (la manière dont le dirigeant agit pour soulager ceux qui souffrent). Ce cadre permet une compréhension nuancée des liens entre la cruauté et le populisme et apporte une contribution originale et de pointe à ces deux corpus de travaux. Nous utilisons notre modèle bidimensionnel du comportement cruel pour apporter un éclairage sur les différentes façons dont les populistes d'extrême droite adoptent la cruauté dans le cadre de leurs stratégies politiques. Nous en sommes arrivés à trois types « idéaux » de comportement cruel du populisme d'extrême droite: la dédramatisation, le Blaming et le conspirationnisme. Pour développer nos idées, nous nous sommes appuyés sur l'analyse qualitative du président populiste d'extrême droite brésilien, Jair Bolsonaro, et de ses (in)actions concernant le COVID-19. Face au nombre en très forte hausse des décès liés au COVID-19, ce dernier a une fois tout simplement répondu: « Et alors? Que voulez-vous que j'y fasse? ». Nous nous sommes basés sur cette étude de cas pour illustrer empiriquement les différentes manières dont la cruauté pouvait se manifester en pratique et les conséquences qu'elle pouvait avoir dans la vie réelle.

In less than two years, the COVID-19 virus has taken (at least) over 4.5 million lives worldwide.[1] The reaction of world leaders has been overwhelmingly somber, with statements of sympathy to those who have lost loved ones. The public message from most leaders—or those who want to be in leadership positions—has been of sorrow for the human tragedy, even if no one can know with certainty which are expressions of a true sentiment or not. Almost none has been openly and unapologetically dismissive about the lives lost, the suffering from those losses, and the fear of dying or having a loved one die because of COVID-19.

However, such callous indifference has been a frequent companion of the Brazilian President Jair Bolsonaro and his response to the country's COVID-19 deaths. For example, in late April 2020, when the total death toll from COVID-19

[1] According to WHO data (https://covid19.who.int/) in mid-September 2021.

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in Brazil had just reached five hundred thousand, surpassing China's figures—a key reference point at the time—a journalist questioned him on this. He replied with contempt and said: "*So what?* What do you want me to do?."[2] This was not the first nor would it be the last time he would publicly and unapologetically display a lack of empathy for the dead from COVID-19 or their families. Yet, this phrase seems to capture the essence of his approach to this pandemic in Brazil, which one and a half year later (September 2021) had taken almost six hundred thousand lives, the world's second highest in absolute numbers. Even with poll numbers plummeting at a crossroads of economic, political, and health turmoil, President Bolsonaro's dismissal of the suffering of fellow countrymen and women caused by the virus has remained a common staple of his political repertoire—with little condemnation from his hardcore supporters. In this context, we characterize President Bolsonaro's approach to deaths from the COVID-19 pandemic as cruel. More specifically, a case of cruelty, based on *indifference* and inaction, condensed in the reaction "so what?."

A reasonable expectation in democracies is that elected leaders would not want to be seen as cruel. This prompts some puzzling questions: why would a political leader *embrace* cruelty? Why choose to display (and praise) lack of empathy as a political quality? We believe the answer is not found in individual flaws or psychological traits but rather in a political style attached to an ideology—namely, populists of the radical right. We argue that cruelty is a type of political behavior common to radical right populists (RRP), a category that includes leaders such as Donald Trump in the United States, Viktor Orbán in Hungary, Rodrigo Duterte in the Philippines, and Jair Bolsonaro in Brazil, because of RRP's exclusionary nature. In other words, RRP tend to build their platforms upon the exclusion of the outgroups (such as immigrants, refugees, or ethnic/religious minorities) rather than on broadening the inclusion of members of the ingroup, as in the case of radical leftist populists' poor-oriented approach (Mudde and Kaltwasser 2012). We, therefore, assume that supporters of exclusionary narratives and policies will be more likely to reward cruelty toward members of the outgroup. Under the rule of RRP, cruelty is manifested through both (1) an exclusionary political ideology, which generally treats pluralism as illegitimate and paints adversaries as enemies to be subdued (or even destroyed), and (2) an exclusionary political style, which further dehumanizes "the other" (elites or lesser minorities) as part of a narrative that seeks to construct a monist, homogeneous social identity by silencing dissent and opposition (Mudde 2017; Carter 2018).

Notwithstanding the vast material on populism and on cruelty, the specificities of the relationship between the two concepts have not been fully explored by either body of literature. This article speaks to both, addressing this gap by providing a better understanding of the dynamics that make cruelty particularly appealing to RRP. We believe the combined study of cruelty and populism—particularly, cruelty and RRP—can shed light on how and why cruelty can be framed as a quality. Another important aspect of our article is to focus on cruelty from a broader perspective than typically investigated, spotlighting cruelty through indifference and inaction. Assuming "people are more willing to engage in moral violations by *omission* than by commission" (DeScioli, Christner, and Kurzban 2011, 442; emphasis added), this latter focus has a significant impact on how cruelty should be studied, especially in the context of democratically elected governments and minimally functioning political institutions. By looking at the politics of cruelty in democratic environments, we seek to further conceptualize it as a political tool not only of brutal and sadist dictators, as the literature would suggest, but also of populists who garner power and support by making or, most often, letting others suffer.

This is a qualitative study whose contribution is two-fold. First, we propose a reconceptualization of cruelty based on two dimensions of political behavior—action (toward the alleviation of suffering) and empathy (toward those who suffer). In democratic contexts, where cruelty by omission/indifference prevails, we have identified three different types of cruel politics: cruelty as treating the suffering of others as irrelevant or unimportant (*downplaying*); as showing occasional empathy toward the pain of others, not moving to alleviate it, and shifting the blame to opponents for not taking action (*blaming*); and as disregarding suffering as a made-up part of a broader conspiracy (*conspiring*). To illustrate those categories, we have opted for a case-study approach, which allows us to address and explore the conceptual categories in greater depth. The Brazilian President Jair Bolsonaro's COVID-19 response provides an adequate case for three reasons. First, Bolsonaro is one of the textbook examples of the current wave of RRP getting to power and embracing cruelty as a political tool (Casarões and Farias 2021; Guimarães and Silva 2021). Second, Bolsonaro's response to COVID-19 has arguably been the most negligent among populists (RRP or otherwise) in democracies (Meyer 2020), providing us with a (sadly) vast array of types of cruel behavior. Third, the literature on populism is relatively scarce when it comes to cases in the global south, even more acutely when studying RRP, which is overwhelmingly attentive to Europe. Thus, the case offers a unique opportunity to juxtapose conceptual understandings of (and the relationship between) cruelty and populism while adding to the still incipient literature on RRP in the global south. The contribution is both theoretical and empirical, demonstrating some of the many ways in which cruelty and populism can reinforce each other.

To pursue these analyses, the paper is divided into five sections. The first section briefly summarizes discussions over the meaning of cruelty and clarifies the one adopted in our analysis. The second section looks at the interface of cruelty and populism, particularly the elements within populism that foster cruelty. The next two sections address the empirical case. The third section provides context, looking at the broad contours of cruelty and populism under President Bolsonaro, with the fourth section addressing the specific manifestations of cruelty in his approach to COVID-19. The fifth and final section concludes this article by drawing the main lessons learned from the analysis.

## Cruelty and Politics

Cruelty is an example of a "thick ethical concept" (Williams 1985), that is, one embedded with both descriptive and normative content, simultaneously describing a fact in the world and evaluating it (Stinneford 2016, 446–51). Like many other social concepts, there is ambiguity and controversy in the literature over how to define what is—and is not—cruelty. The word itself derives from the Latin *crudus*, meaning rough/raw, therefore implying "morally raw." The *Oxford English Dictionary* describes "cruel," when referring to persons, as "disposed to inflict suffering; indifferent to or taking pleasure in another's pain or distress; destitute of kindness or compassion; merciless, pitiless, hard-hearted,"

[2] Transcript of exchange (in Portuguese) available at https://bit.ly/2UEiYlP.

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and when referring to actions, as "proceeding from or showing indifference to or pleasure in another's distress." Simply put, cruelty is the quality of being cruel.

The literature devoted to studying cruelty tends to focus on a "narrow" understanding of the concept. Here, cruelty is (1) most connected to a conscious intention to inflict pain and where (2) the one inflicting it generally takes pleasure from the action. A well-known example of this approach is found in Nell's biological/evolutionary analysis of cruelty, which he defines as "the deliberate infliction of physical or psychological pain on other living creatures, sometimes indifferently, but often with delight" (Nell 2006, 211). We do not dispute the understanding that cruelty can—and frequently does—manifest itself through deliberate acts of pain, which generate pleasure for the actor inflicting it, nor that there can be biological elements prompting cruelty. However, we find this definitional approach incomplete, for at least two reasons. First, it leaves out a broad range of situations pertaining to *how* cruelty is manifested. Cruelty should not have to be limited to a purposeful action to cause suffering (see Stinneford 2016, 463–85). Such a threshold leaves out the deliberate *indifference* to others' pain (regardless of its cause), which is particularly cruel when one could take actions that could alleviate others' suffering but chooses not to. For example, in the wake of a natural disaster destroying a community, a cruel response can be "I am glad this happened to them" *as well as* "I couldn't care less about what happened to them." In an empathy "scale,"[3] indifference is not a midway point between being glad and upset if something bad happened to someone else. Rather, "I don't care about their pain" sits in the same low empathy realm as delight in others' pain. A binary understanding of cruelty as glad/upset underplays another accompanying dynamic: *responsiveness* to what is causing others' pain—an element of crucial political importance. Instead of only two main options (action to create pain versus reaction to cease pain), unresponsiveness is not a neutral stance and can also be characterized as cruelty. Of course, there is an important caveat, related to legal obligations (or the lack thereof). One must separate not being able to respond due to legal constraints from *choosing* to not respond; also, those who, due to legal obligations, must implement/support an action they personally consider cruel but have no control over.

Teasing out this scenario shows that someone in a leadership position can demonstrate (or even feel) pleasure or indifference to others' suffering while still providing (some level of) relief for those in need, whether prompted by social or political constraints, or because mandated by law to respond. As such, a decision-maker publicly showing low empathy can still act toward minimizing others' pain. However, if there are limited external constraints—let alone rewards—for showing low empathy, there is a greater space for a leader to be openly glad/indifferent and choose to be the source of pain and remain unresponsive to it. We call this space of no/low empathy toward others' pain and no/low action to alleviate such pain the cruelty "zone" (figure 1).

The second contestation to the biological approach starts by recognizing that human cruelty might have animal origins but at the same time understands cruelty as a phenomenon overlaid and transformed by cultural and ideological meaning (Behrendt 2006, 226). What makes an action be labeled cruel or not can only be properly understood contextually (see Shklar 1982; Williams 1985). Religious beliefs, cultural rituals, and social values provide several examples of practices that are normal to those in-group but cruel to "outsiders" or whose meaning (as they pertain to cruelty) has changed over time: male circumcision in infants, scarification of teenagers, encouragement of self-flagellation, allowing women in field combat operations, etc. While we bracket the discussions over cruelty regarding these issues, they all serve to highlight cruelty's intersubjective component. Along with religion and culture, there is a growing body of research demonstrating that cruelty and other large-scale inhumanities are heavily rooted in ideology (Bandura 1999, 2006; Haritos-Fatouros 2003; Moshman 2007; Kivisto 2019). This approach challenges the conceptualizations of cruelty based on Hobbesian or evolutionary lenses (e.g., Nell 2006), which treat cruelty as an inherent human characteristic and mostly detached from a social environment. We follow the former line of investigation, where to understand cruelty in politics, it is essential to understand social context.

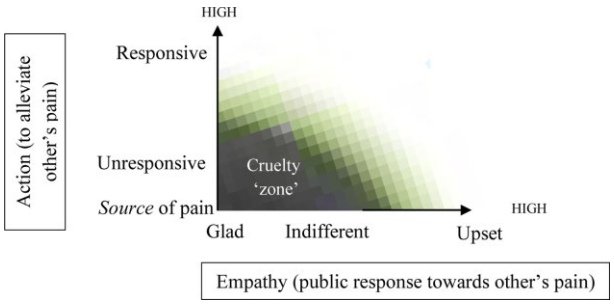



**Figure 1.** Two-dimensional model of cruel behavior in politics.

In tandem, research shows that "people judge others' wrongful omissions less harshly than others' wrongful commissions" (DeScioli, Christner, and Kurzban 2011, 442).[4] Thus, cruelty via omission is expected to have fewer negative repercussions than deliberate cruelty—even if both lead to the same result. This finding matters for political decision-making, particularly in democratic settings: it is (relatively) easy to "spin" a narrative over cruel indifference and inaction by arguing on the lines of "there is nothing I can do," "this is how things are," or "I can't control death."[5] Politicians of all stripes do this, usually as a way of convincing public opinion they are *not* cruel. As we will develop in the following sections, RRP leaders are known for embracing public demonstrations of cruelty (including indifference) toward certain groups. Yet, because they still sit within a democratic setting, even if a weak one, they might have legal restrictions or electoral considerations constraining them from commissioning cruel actions. It is in this space that omission is particularly appealing to RRP: the leader's failure to mitigate suffering helps to maintain the veneer of empathy and respect for liberal democratic values, while providing opportunities to blame inaction on *constraints* from competing sources of power (e.g., legal system, courts, political parties, subnational entities).

[3] We recognize that "empathy scale" is an established research topic in psychology (e.g., Hogan 1969; Davis 1983; Jolliffee and Farrington 2006). In our article, this term is used differently as we focus on public demonstrations of empathy by political leaders and its use for political purposes. Thus, we leave aside assessments over individual leaders' internal "true" feelings of empathy.

[4] See also Spranca et al. (1991), Ritov and Baron (1992), Royzman and Baron (2002), Anderson (2003).

[5] Since political leaders' actions (or lack thereof) can have life and death implications, cruelty through indifference and purposeful inaction in the face of a pandemic can be seen as an expression of "necropolitics" (Mbembe 2003), that is, sovereignty as an exercise of control over mortality and definition of life as the deployment and manifestation of power.

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## Cruelty and Populism

Cruelty as a "normal" part of politics has increasingly become a taboo in the last century, particularly the kind where the state (and/or state representatives) is the one purposely inflicting pain. This has been exemplified by bans on chemical weapons (Price 1995, 2018), move to more "humane" forms of executing the death penalty (Ryan 2010), laws condemning physical punishments and torture (Asad 1996), slavery (Abruzzo 2011), female genital mutilation (Rahman & Nahid 2000), etc. In the nineteenth century, laws prohibiting acts considered cruel became increasingly used as a marker to separate "civilized" from "uncivilized" nations (see Bain 2003, 1–17). After world war II, cruelty exercised by the state or its representatives has become antithetical not only to democracies but also to the liberal international order itself.

Notwithstanding its taboo-like status, it is reasonable to argue that (1) cruelty can happen in any kind of political system and (2) it is more likely to happen the fewer guardrails there are—legal, political, moral. Thus, while it is more expected to appear in authoritarian and totalitarian regimes, cruelty can also take root in democracies, particularly under populist and "hybrid" regimes (Levitsky and Way 2002). We cannot claim, however, that cruelty is an inherent part of all kinds of populism. We argue that the "populist radical right" widens the justifications for cruelty and is more likely to embrace cruelty openly while being (or seeking to be) rewarded by their supporters.

Why is that so? Cas Mudde (2007) claims that the radical right has a core ideology that includes (at least) three elements: nativism, authoritarianism, and populism. Nativism is defined as a mix of nationalism and xenophobia. It is an ideology that states should be inhabited solely by members of the native group ("the nation") and non-native group (or "alien" elements) regardless of whether individuals or ideas pose a fundamental danger to the homogenous nation state. The nativist distinction can be based on numerous factors, including ethnic, racial, and religious prejudices, which are frequently combined in one form or another. Authoritarianism refers to the belief in a rigorously ordered society in which violations of authority are to be harshly punished. Most right-wing ideologies, as well as many religions, share this ideological characteristic.

Populism, like so many other terms in the political vocabulary, does not have a settled definition. Understanding the controversial nature of populism is, in fact, an essential element of the literature on the subject. In contemporary literature, there are five main approaches to populism: as an ideology (Mudde 2004, 2007; Abts and Rummens 2007; Kaltwasser 2012, 2014; Rooduijn 2014), as a strategy (Di Tella 1965; Smith 1969; Ianni 1975, Weffort 1978; Weyland 2001; Ellner 2003; Roberts 2003, 2006), as a discourse (Hawkins 2009; Koopmans and Muis 2009; de la Torre, 2010; Gidron and Bonikowski 2013), as a political logic (Laclau 2005), and as political style (Canovan 1984, 1999; Knight 1998; Jagers and Walgrave 2007; Moffitt 2016). In this piece, we adopt Benjamin Moffitt's approach of populism as a political style, which is defined as "the repertoires of embodied, symbolically mediated performance made to audiences that are used to create and navigate the fields of power that comprise the political, stretching from the domain of government through to everyday life" (Moffitt 2016, 37–38). From this perspective, populism has three key features: (1) an appeal to "the people" versus "the elite," (2) the widespread use of bad manners, and (3) the establishment of a narrative of crisis, breakdown, or threats (Moffitt 2016, 52). Populism, if viewed as a political style, may be used by leaders of many ideological currents.

The binary societal division supported by RRP tends to existentially oppose "the people" and "the elite," as conceived by Carl Schmitt. Schmitt sketches a category and a criterion for identification in political action by way of distancing friendship and enmity. In Schmitt's concept of the political, "the other, the stranger is sufficient for his nature that he is, in an especially intense way, existentially something different and alien, so that in the extreme case conflicts with him are possible," which in "case of emergency" implies "the existential negation of another being" (Schmitt 2007, 27). According to De Ruiter (2012, 60), the Schmittian existential negation of another being leads to "moral stigmatization, criminalization and dehumanization" of what RRP considers "the enemy." Cruelty serves as a bonding mechanism, creating and strengthening group solidarity (Serwer 2018; Steele 2021, 2). As a result, in the face of a public health crisis, dehumanizing the other provides an enabling atmosphere for the populist leader to justify cruel actions.

The studies on "emotional populism" offer another dimension of how the RRP exploits the antagonism between "elite" and "people." According to Demertzis (2006), populism is a political phenomenon fueled by resentment. Or, as defined by Shils (1956), populism is "an ideology of resentment against the social establishment imposed by the long-term domination of a class." That is, resentment, mobilized by populists against the elites, incites negative feelings such as malice, annoyance, envy, grudgingly, rancor, jealousy, and spite (Scheler 1961, 46–48). The mechanism that helps us understand the power (and the perils) of emotional populism is the transformation of resentment into dehumanization. When negative sentiments mobilized by populists are channeled toward a particular group, exclusionary behavior such as cruelty and violence starts to pay off, even in democratic contexts.

Research on genocide and mass killings help to understand dehumanization. For Moshman (2007), there is a path toward genocide, manifested in four steps: dichotomization, dehumanization, destruction, and denial. There is a growing consensus among those who study these topics that these acts are *not* perpetrated by evil monsters or psychopathic individuals who are incapable of having any empathy. Rather, these acts are "mostly perpetrated by ordinary people playing social roles in groups, institutions, and practices to which they are politically, religiously, philosophically, ideologically, morally, professionally, economically, and/or personally committed" (Moshman 2007, 117). Of course, genocide and cruelty are not the same. Nonetheless, this framing is useful for our analysis, as it connects cruelty with identity, particularly the dichotomized worldview that characterizes populism and facilitates the dehumanization of "the other." Thus, a populist is less likely to be punished—if not *rewarded*—by its followers (who see themselves as the "true people") for cruel behavior if such actions are framed as affecting "the other," deemed deserving of bad things and for whom little empathy is warranted.

The second characteristic of populist leaders' style is "bad manners." This is understood as a coarsening of political discourse, as well as a disdain for "appropriate" forms of political action, as a feature of populist actors' appeal to "the people" as arbiters of "common sense," the "way forward," and the urgency of the issues they raise (Moffitt 2016). As such, cruelty can (once again) easily dovetail with populism. A populist leader is much more likely (compared to a non-populist) to *openly* and *unapologetically* say (and do) cruel things, particularly to those not considered part of "the

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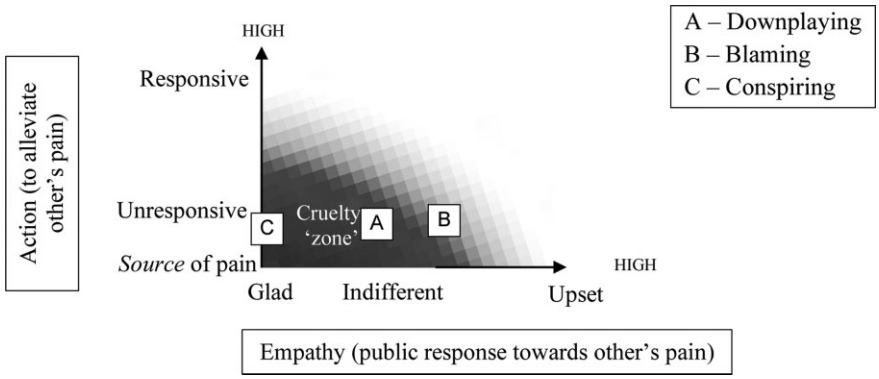



**Figure 2.** Types of cruel behavior of RRP.

people." Even when the cruelty is "indiscriminate" (such as Bolsonaro's "so what?" remarks), the populists' followers are likely to be forgiving if the discourse is (re)framed as a quality. It can be seen in justifications of cruel language, such as: "he just says it like it is", "he is blunt, but he is not wrong", or "there should be no room for political correctness."

"Bad manners" is inextricably linked with a defining feature of populism, namely "its reliance on strong leaders who are able to mobilize the masses and/or conduct their parties with the aim of enacting radical reforms" (Mudde and Kaltvasser 2017, 83). Or as Taggart (2000, 1) put it, populism "requires the most extraordinary individuals to lead the most ordinary of people." According to Moffitt (2016, 66), the most common way populist leaders use to demonstrate they are not "regular politicians" is by employing "bad manners." This relates to populist leaders' seeming contempt for "proper" political behavior as well as their willful disregard for such expectations and practices. The term's ambiguity is intentional, since these demonstrations of "poor manners" can take many forms, including self-presentation, the use of slang, political incorrectness, fashion, or other displays of contempt for "normal" practices of "respectable" politics.

Depending on the country's political culture where the populist leader mobilizes, her or his "extraordinary" character manifests itself in a variety of ways. In countries where a sexist and authoritarian tradition persists, the populist is portrayed with emphasis on his virility and as a charismatic strongman based on the "cult of the leader," which presents the leader as a macho and sometimes aggressive character (Mudde and Kaltwasser 2017, 64–66). The *caudillo*, a generic word derived from the Latin *caput* (head), is the stereotypical populist leader in Latin America. It refers to a powerful leader who wields authority independent of any position and without restraint (Mudde and Kaltwasser 2017, 63). An army colonel turned civil politician, Juan Perón served in both authoritarian and democratic governments in Argentina. More recent examples of populist strongmen are Venezuela's Hugo Chávez and Brazil's Jair Bolsonaro, both military officials who entered politics with a promise of honesty and renewal. All of them reinforced their political stance by exploiting the existing misogynistic environments, where "bad manners" were conflated with expectations for "strong*men*" behavior. Cruelty—such as manifested by indifference toward others' pain—is frequently repackaged as "manly leadership," where feelings toward others are chastised as excessively feminine. As such, empathy is not a quality but rather as a weakness.

Finally, populism is driven by a sense of crisis, collapse, or danger, with dramatization and performance being used to generate that sense of catastrophe (Moffitt 2016, 52–56). Yet, populism does not dictate a priori what is the issue that will lead to catastrophe. One would expect that in the face of a global pandemic, for example, containing the spread of the disease would be the obvious choice for any leader, populist or not. However, let us suppose a leader does not believe that something deemed a danger by experts is *really* dangerous or that recognizing the danger could put his/her popularity at risk. In such cases, the source of crisis can very well be (mis)directed somewhere else (e.g., immigrants, communism, capitalism). This relates to another important development of Moffitt's concept that regards the opposition between "the people" and "the technocratic elites," which would encompass the scientific and academic community. In this sense, whereas populists appeal to "the people" against "the elite," claiming that "common sense" or "the people's wisdom" should be trusted, technocrats accept expertise and specialized training and, for the most part, are indifferent toward "the people" as an exclusive segment of society.

Moffitt's elements of the populist style are the building blocks of a further conceptualization of cruel politics. As previously discussed, figure 1 depicts a "cruelty zone" where, on the one hand, the leader or the government is either the source of pain or unresponsive to it and, on the other, there is little to no empathy toward the suffering of others. Since democratically elected populists are not likely to inflict pain on their own citizens (unless it is targeted against specific segments of society that have been dehumanized, such as criminals or religious minorities), it is fair to assume that these populists will mostly produce suffering by omission or negligence. In other words, responsivity is always low. What varies, as we will see, is the degree of empathy—genuine or simulated.

In figure 2, we have established three types of cruel behavior in the context of radical right populism. The first is *downplaying* (the gravity of the situation), in which the leader demonstrates occasional empathy for those who suffer, usually when prompted to do so, but does not act to alleviate their pain because doing so would force him/her to acknowledge that the circumstances are more troublesome than previously admitted. In this type, we see the continuous redefinition of the lines separating the people (who do not deserve suffering) and the elites (who deserve), in which targets move according to the populist's narratives and convenience. The second is *blaming* (those who act contrariwise), in which the leader pretends to be trying to ease the suffering (high empathy) but others are trying to stop him. This is when Moffitt's notion of crisis, collapse, or danger comes in. The populist pits the people (supporters, more

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specifically) against those others by fostering and deepening a sense of crisis created not by the leader but by the obstacles to addressing it. The third is *conspiring*, in which the leader claims that neither the crisis nor the suffering stemming from it is real but an invention of opponents/enemies to make him/her look bad. This is as close as it gets to the populist inflicting pain directly by accusing the victims of making up the suffering and generally resorting to all kinds of bad manners to get his/her point across. In the next section, we present the empirical case and show how cruelty and populism can appear in the "real" world.

## Case Study: Cruelty, Populism, and the COVID-19 Pandemic in Bolsonaro's Brazil

How do these categories of cruel behavior play out in RRP governments? In this section, we explore the Brazilian President Jair Bolsonaro's response to the COVID-19 health emergency. But first, a brief note on case selection and methodology. We have chosen this particular crisis because of its natural (as opposed to political) origins and global implications, allowing us to evaluate responses undertaken by populists and non-populists from all points of the political spectrum. Narrowing down our sample to how populists responded to COVID-19, they were not uniform in dealing with the pandemic neither did they all downplay the seriousness of the emergency (Mudde 2020)—unlike what was generally assumed at the outset of the crisis (Harris 2020; Paracha 2020; Zabala 2020). Out of the seventeen populists in power when the pandemic broke out, only five did not take the crisis seriously: Belarus's Alexander Lukashenko, Brazil's Jair Bolsonaro, Mexico's Andrés Manuel López-Obrador (a.k.a. AMLO), Nicaragua's Daniel Ortega, and the United States' Donald Trump (Meyer 2020).

Zeroing in on the liberal democracies, presidents Trump and Bolsonaro may be considered radical right (or exclusionary) populists, whereas López-Obrador is a left-wing (or an inclusionary) populist. The fact that all of them initially downplayed the crisis does not mean they were equally cruel: AMLO, a comparatively stronger president than his radical right counterparts, thanks to a congressional supermajority, has adopted a series of ill-conceived policies—from a scant testing plan to a deliberate herd-immunity approach, under the controversial guidance of the Deputy Health Minister Dr López-Gatell, the nation's "coronavirus czar"—framing them as an attempt to save jobs in a highly informal economy. Although the Mexican government has refused to recognize their own mistakes and omissions, the country's early vaccination rollout revealed a significant change of course (Cattan and Silver 2021). While we do not intend to investigate why other RRP have responded differently, we may suggest that in Brazil and the United States, cruelty by indifference was the outcome of a combination between a politically weak populist (constrained by both horizontal and vertical checks and balances), economic pressures, and electoral imperatives. Bolsonaro has even attempted to frame his early COVID-19 response as pro-poor and pro-jobs, but, as his US ally and role model, his government quickly slid to a divisive "us versus them" narrative in which defenders of social distancing, mandatory masking, and universal vaccination became enemies to be combatted.

Brazil is an interesting and meaningful case because it showcases cruelty at its highest in a region where conciliation and compromise were the norm in politics. Under Bolsonaro, the country has seen a relevant departure from the decades-long Latin American trend of inclusionary forms of populism, which includes not only the more recent left-wing populist wave but also the right-wing/neoliberal populists of the 1990s (Mudde and Kaltwasser 2012). Such a break with the past is indicative that the exclusionary strategy of dehumanizing the outgroup started to pay off as political polarization increased, and new socioeconomic cleavages emerged (Hunter and Power 2019). Bolsonaro arguably provides the most illustrative example of how cruelty became a component of the political repertoire of populists in contemporary democracies, particularly regarding responses to the health emergency. Although most of Bolsonaro's recent political trajectory has been constructed along the lines of Trump's narratives, policies, and behavior, when it comes to the COVID-19 crisis, even when the US president backed off, Bolsonaro doubled down in belittling the pandemic. This may be so because the Brazilian president, who polished his RRP style over many decades, has frequently leaned toward cruelty. Consequently, when elected president on an openly cruel platform, he saw no political benefits in toning down or changing course, even in extreme circumstances that demanded technical expertise and moderation, as the COVID-19 pandemic. Therefore, Bolsonaro's response to the health crisis is exemplary because it provides a vast array of cruel behaviors based on inaction or indifference.

We have divided the case analysis in two parts. First, we show how cruelty has always been an integral part of Bolsonaro's populist style and how it became more central as he decided to run for president on a radical right platform, in the context of growing political polarization. An important facet of Bolsonaro's populism lies in the way he mobilizes individual or collective resentment, driven by a desire for vengeance against the oppressor (real or imagined) and strengthened by a sense of inferiority to disrupt the established system (Romano 2019), a point we will also address. Second, we explore Bolsonaro administration's response to the COVID-19 pandemic, seeking to demonstrate that the president has embraced all three forms of cruelty—downplaying, blaming, and conspiring—when addressing the public health emergency. In both parts, we rely on Bolsonaro's speeches, interviews, and statements (online and offline), including material from high-level officials whose declarations were openly or tacitly subscribed by the president. Through those primary sources, we aim to provide empirical evidence to the connection between radical right populism, the narratives of cruelty, and cruel behavior.

### *The forging of a cruel radical right populist*

Cruelty has always been part of Bolsonaro's persona and of his trajectory as an RRP. Although he had become notorious for his bluntness, impoliteness, and violence since entering politics in the late 1980s, cruelty has played a key role in Bolsonaro's rising popularity since the early 2010s. It was an integral element of his 2018 presidential bid and has been embraced as part of the Bolsonaro administration's governing strategy, with considerable policy implications. The banalization and occasional exaltation of others' suffering, notably political adversaries, lies at a crossroads between the populist style and the radical right ideology. In this section, we make the case for Bolsonaro as an RRP and discuss how his deliberately cruel approach to politics—which has always been part of his political persona—has developed into a successful and effective trademark along his path to the presidency.

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The retired army captain made a loud entrance into politics in 1988, paving the way toward the federal House of Representatives voicing the petty demands of low-ranked military officials. Bolsonaro was never an active congressman during his twenty-eight years in the role. Yet, his staunch defense of sovereignty, economic protectionism, and the legacy of the military dictatorship (which he conveniently calls "revolution") made him an extremely controversial character (see Shalders 2017; Agencia Lupa 2019). In 1999, amid a large-scale privatization program spearheaded by President Fernando Henrique Cardoso (1995–2002), Bolsonaro said in an interview that he would like to see Cardoso shot dead: "We will not change anything in this country through elections. Anything. Unfortunately, things will only change when we wage a full-scale civil war here. And completing a task the military regime has left behind: killing some 30 thousand, starting with Cardoso" (in Almeida 2018).

Bravados like those were common but usually fell in deaf ears. Cruelty as a political rhetoric was not taken seriously in a country committed to consolidating its democracy and where centrist politics was the norm. Bolsonaro's performance was stable but lackluster. However, tides began to turn in 2014, when Bolsonaro quadrupled his votes and became Rio's most voted congressman. How did that happen? There are three common explanations as to why Bolsonaro's popularity skyrocketed over the 2010s: First, growing polarization of Brazilian politics along the Workers' Party President Dilma Rousseff's first term in office (2012–2015), fueled by the clash between identity politics (involving gender, race, and sexual diversity issues) and a conservative-religious reaction (Cruz, Kaysel, and Codas 2015); second, his symbiotic relationship with political comedy shows and tabloid talk shows, whose ratings soared whenever he proudly exhibited his homophobic, misogynistic, and authoritarian positions (Stycer 2018); third, Bolsonaro's early and effective adoption of social media tools, including messaging apps such as WhatsApp, to spread his blunt and often violent rants against several targets he claimed were enemies of Brazil's "good citizens"—from the Rousseff administration to gays, feminists, communists, and criminals (Oliveira 2018).

By helping Bolsonaro construct his image as an RRP, cruelty suddenly seemed to pay off. One episode might be considered a watershed in ripening Bolsonaro's populist style. In 2014, he gave an interview where he attacked the government for "turning" children into homosexuals, bashed gays for their demands of more severe punishments for homophobic-driven violence, praised death penalty and made fun of staggering prison violence, and criticized affirmative action policies by saying that, if he were chosen to preside over the commission, he would be "color-blind." "My proposal is to stand up for the rights of the majority, and not of the minority. Minorities must silence and bow to the majority" (in Borges and Calgaro 2014).

Between 2014 and 2018, Bolsonaro carefully forged his populist approach to politics, using cruelty as a key element. Following Moffitt's (2016) definition, the first trait of Bolsonaro's unique style was the permanent division between "the people" and "the elites." He often claimed that such elites represented a wide group of left-wing politicians, journalists, and academics who waved the flag of human rights, particularly minority rights, used to protect subversive behavior (from homosexuality to pedophilia, usually treated as synonyms) and all sorts of criminal activity (from corruption to drug trafficking, which he frequently associated with the Workers' Party). Second, through the systematic use of fake news, memes, and other forms of social media tools, Bolsonaro advanced numerous conspiracy theories, stirring a sense of crisis among conservative Brazilians, such as Rousseff administration's alleged promotion of a "gay kit" to teach "homosexuality" to children in public schools and an all-encompassing plot undertaken by the Brazilian left to establish a transnational communist state. Third, Bolsonaro's politically incorrect rhetoric, fraught with curse words and targeted harassments, became a symbol of the congressman's raw "authenticity," distinguishing him from the political establishment and bringing him closer to the "average" person. A showcase of Bolsonaro's bad manners was seen in his speech over Rousseff's impeachment (April 2016), which he dedicated to "the memory of Colonel Brilhante Ustra, Dilma Rousseff's worst nightmare" (in Della Barba and Wentzel 2016), lauding the man who brutally tortured her during Brazil's dictatorship years.

In the weeks following Rousseff's impeachment vote, Bolsonaro made his presidential candidacy official, quickly jumping to fourth place in the polls (G1 2016). In parallel, Trump's Republican nomination and eventual election gave Bolsonaro the necessary legitimacy to run an unconventional and divisive campaign, boosted by social media and based on sheer cruelty. But whereas Trump ran his populist-driven campaign around the construction of external enemies (Mexicans, Muslims, China, etc.), Bolsonaro focused on attacking domestic foes, especially leftists, activists, and minorities. By turning his campaign slogan "Brazil above everything, God above everyone" into the cornerstone of his governing strategy, Bolsonaro has attempted to turn the Brazilian society into a conservative monolith by eliminating any manifestation of pluralism or political dissent, contributing to the cruel dehumanization of those who do not belong to the majority group.

### *Cruelty in the Bolsonaro administration's approach to the COVID-19 pandemic*

The Bolsonaro administration's response to the COVID-19 crisis reveals how cruelty moved beyond a mere populist tool to become state policy. It is now known that the government decided to adopt a herd-immunity approach from the outset of the pandemic, stimulating the spread of the disease among the young and adult population (against whom it was believed the coronavirus was not lethal), treating them with scientifically unproven drugs such as hydroxychloroquine and ivermectin, and refusing to implement nationwide restrictive measures (Ventura, Aith, and Reis 2021). Although government officials, including the president, have denied deliberately exposing Brazilians to the disease, a careful analysis of the timeline of COVID-19-related events in Brazil, combined with recent findings from the Parliamentary Inquiry Commission (a senate committee created to investigate the administration's response to the pandemic), reveals that *widespread contagion* was Bolsonaro's unofficial policy. However cruel and absurd that might sound, we must understand that the president has attempted to frame COVID-19 in a counterintuitive way. According to the government's narrative—widely propagated by supporters and congressional allies—cruelty lies not in allowing the disease to spread but in trying to suppress fundamental individual liberties, including the right not to wear a mask and not to take vaccines, boasting "freedom is more important than life itself."

The consequences have been as devastating as they are predictable: as of mid-November 2021, Brazil accumulated over six hundred thousand COVID-19 deaths, second only

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to the United States; over twenty-one million reported cases (Worldometers). To make things worse, the health crisis takes place in the context of a prolonged economic recession and recurring attacks on democratic institutions, most of the time stirred by Bolsonaro himself. Even though many governors and mayors have attempted to adopt more severe local restrictions, and despite Brazil's otherwise remarkable public healthcare capacity to rapidly deploy vaccines nationwide, the terrible response to COVID-19 is primarily the outcome of a deteriorating political and economic landscape under the rule of an RRP with little to no commitment to democracy, science, or even civility.

Against the backdrop of high unemployment, increasing poverty, unprecedented political polarization, and institutional breakdown, Bolsonaro has largely ignored the insurmountable human costs of the pandemic to preserve economic activity and to safeguard his own popularity. Cruelty has been an integral element of how Bolsonaro has addressed all those issues. In this section, we will explore three aspects of his administration's COVID-19 policies: negligence, polarization, and conspiracy. They speak directly to Moffitt's (2016) framework: by neglecting the suffering of all those who have been hit by the sanitary crisis, Bolsonaro has exercised his bad manners, reinforcing the image of the strongman who will not waste time mourning deaths and will tirelessly work to save jobs. By fostering polarization and antagonizing Congress, the Supreme Court, governors, mayors, the mainstream media, and scientists, Bolsonaro has successfully developed a narrative of permanent struggle between himself, the populist leader, and the enemies of the people, insensitive to the dire economic situation. Finally, by disseminating conspiracy theories involving some of those enemies as well as external ones (China, the World Health Organization [WHO], "globalists," etc.), Bolsonaro has been able to divert the responsibility for the crisis from himself and stimulate the creation of "parallel crisis"—summarized in the notion that the real struggle was one between totalitarianism (lockdown, masks, social distancing, mandatory vaccination) and individual liberties.

***Downplaying.*** For a president who became internationally known for the cruelty with which he addressed the evolution of COVID-19 in Brazil, it is hard to choose just a few remarks as evidence of his negligent behavior. Let us begin with the outbreak of the pandemic. For the initial weeks after the WHO declared the global emergency in early March 2020, Bolsonaro frequently minimized the seriousness of disease, claiming that the danger of the virus was being overplayed "perhaps for economic reasons," blaming governors and the media for "hysteria" over the virus (the day after the first death from COVID-19 in Brazil), and calling it a "little flu" at least three times before the cameras (BBC 2020).

Unlike other populist leaders, however, the exponential rise in the number of cases and deaths did not cause Bolsonaro to abandon his rather cynical views on the pandemic. Being no longer able to deny that the disease was indeed lethal, he moved on to a two-pronged strategy: to normalize the casualties as part of a natural trajectory of the disease and to question the death toll figures as exaggerated. As for the first aspect of Bolsonaro's strategy, in April 2020 alone, he said two of his most remembered rants when asked by journalists about the country's worsening situation: "Look, man, I'm not a gravedigger" (Brazil had 2,584 deaths) and "So what? I'm sorry, what do you want me to do?" (5,050 deaths). Bolsonaro's negligence hit the headlines internationally and concerned scientists and politicians, who started to picture Brazil as a global health threat. An editorial of The Lancet (2020) criticized the Brazilian administration for its chaotic response to COVID-19: "Such disarray at the heart of the administration is a deadly distraction in the middle of a public health emergency and is also a stark sign that Brazil's leadership has lost its moral compass, if it ever had one."

Between May and November 2020, Bolsonaro kept playing down the human suffering caused by COVID-19. After massive criticism over the growing death toll, his administration launched an official "scoreboard of life" to focus on the COVID-19 *recoveries*, rather than deaths, to counter negative press coverage (Lemos 2020). Asked by a supporter to say a word of comfort to those who had lost their loved ones, he replied: "We are sorry for everyone who died, but it's everybody's fate" (Folha de São Paulo 2020). When he revealed he had tested positive for COVID-19, he added that the virus was like the rain, "it's going to hit you sooner or later" (UOL Notícias 2020a). On November 10, as the country's coronavirus death toll surpassed one hundred and sixty-two thousand, Bolsonaro took a step further: "All of us are going to die one day. There is no point in escaping from that, in escaping from reality. We have to stop being a country of sissies" (in Farzan and Berger 2020).

The second aspect of Bolsonaro's strategy of playing down the disease took place in two different moments of the crisis. In the first months that followed the outbreak, he cast doubts on the official death toll figures by suggesting, without any evidence, that the death certificates were doctorated for political reasons, asking his supporters to invade hospitals and film the bed occupancy to expose the fraud (June 12, 2020, 40,919 deaths and 802,828 cases) (UOL Notícias 2020b). Since the beginning of 2021, Bolsonaro has questioned the numbers: "many medical reports are forged" (January 26, 217,664 deaths) (in Fernandes 2021); "It seems like everybody's dying from COVID-19 … how many ICUs really have COVID-19 patients?" (March 18, 285,136 deaths) (in Della Coletta 2021). In June 2021, Bolsonaro went as far as to refer to a fake document, allegedly produced by the Federal General Accounting Office, to claim that 50 percent of COVID-19 deaths in 2020 were not from COVID-19: "of course the mainstream media will not report on that." The government agency had to publicly deny the existence of such a document, later found to have been illegally uploaded by an official who was Bolsonaro's supporter (Fagundes 2021).

As a final take on Bolsonaro's negligence toward the COVID-19 crisis, it seems relevant to point out the numerous times the president has promoted rallies, public events, and sometimes even unrehearsed appearances in streets and markets across the country. The first of such packed gatherings took place on March 15, 2020, just a few days after the WHO had declared the global pandemic, and at a time many believed Bolsonaro could have been infected after a "superspreading" trip to Florida a week earlier ("if I got infected, it's my problem") (G1 2020a). In virtually every crowded event the president joined, he did not wear a mask and sometimes even reprimanded (or made fun of) those who did, from aides to supporters, or who refused to shake hands with him. Even with death tolls soaring in the country, Bolsonaro's rallies were generally celebratory and served his purpose of showing off popular support against his alleged enemies—and in defense of individual rights and freedoms, as we witnessed in the massive September 7, 2021, pro-Bolsonaro demonstrations.

***Blaming.*** Another aspect of Bolsonaro's cruelty toward COVID-19 victims has been his compulsive blame-shifting

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strategy. The president and his administration more broadly have never taken responsibility for the disastrous response to the pandemic on a national level. At first, Bolsonaro has chastised governors and the mainstream media for spreading "hysteria" (Veja 2020), as opposed to his approach that "jobs were as important as lives" (Soares 2021), trying to boycott and hollow out restrictive measures undertaken locally. However, a series of Supreme Court rulings between March and April 2020 determined that the federal government could not interfere with social distancing measures adopted by states or municipalities. It also stressed that, as a federation, it was up to the Bolsonaro administration to coordinate the bulk of response to the pandemic, which should include national social distancing, mask-up, and vaccination campaigns.

The "noninterference" directive of such rulings has served as the perfect pretext for Bolsonaro to turn the blame to governors and mayors while completely ignoring the need for federal coordination. "Go complain with your governor, as the Supreme Court won't let me do my part" (Grillo 2020) was (and still is) one of Bolsonaro's standard answers to journalists and supporters. This posture has allowed the president to pit the people against political adversaries who could threaten his popularity, often rudely: in one single statement, in May 2020, he called the governors of São Paulo and Rio and the mayor of Manaus (locations where the disease was advancing more rapidly) "shit" and "turd" for shutting down commerce and asking people to stay at home (G1 2020b) and has also promoted or stimulated anti-quarantine protests in state capitals. The São Paulo Governor João Doria, in particular, became Bolsonaro's favorite target, out of fears Doria could replace him as the right-wing presidential candidate for 2022.

Bolsonaro's us-versus-them approach to the pandemic highlight two elements of cruelty. First, most anti-quarantine/pro-Bolsonaro protests, besides being openly antidemocratic (calling for a president-led military intervention and the closing of Congress and the Supreme Court), deliberately challenged basic social distancing measures and could be considered superspreading events legitimated by the president. Second, the president has stimulated a widespread dehumanizing campaign against whoever spoke in favor of social distancing. Reports of violence against doctors and other healthcare professionals became commonplace (Lotta et al. 2020). In some motorcades, horns could be heard in front of packed hospitals.

The president's vocal defense of drugs such as hydroxychloroquine and ivermectin as miracle cures for COVID-19 has only worsened the polarization. Another common talking point among Bolsonaro supporters, usually in response to growing accusations that the federal government has adopted a genocidal policy in Brazil, is that the real genocide is being committed by those who have denied the people access to "early treatment" (with unproven medicines) and who should be blamed for the massive COVID-19 death toll across the country (R7 2020). In the early months of the pandemic, two health ministers—Luiz Henrique Mandetta and Nelson Teich—got quickly sacked for not accepting hydroxychloroquine as the official government treatment protocol. Bolsonaro then appointed an Army General, Eduardo Pazuello, for the job. When he took office, in May 2020, Brazil had just surpassed 233,000 cases and 15,633 deaths. When he was finally fired, in March 2021, the country had 11.5 million reported cases and 280,000 casualties.

In one of the most bizarre episodes involving the military minister, Bolsonaro publicly disavowed him for signing an agreement with the São Paulo state government to acquire forty-six million doses of the Sino-Brazilian vaccine Coronavac. On social media, responding to followers who criticized the government for buying vaccines from China, the president called the agreement "treasonous" and reinforced that "no vaccines would be bought." A few days later, Bolsonaro paid a visit to the general minister, who was recovering from COVID-19, and published a video with the minister in which the latter declared: "Gentlemen, it's as simple as that: one orders and the other obeys." Even though the general was still sick, neither cared about wearing masks (Struck 2020).

***Conspiring.*** Vaccines are at the center of the third dimension of Bolsonaro's cruel populism: conspiracies as a means of creating parallel crises—and therefore divert the discussion from the COVID-19 tragedy. It all started with the (highly questionable) notion that "jobs are as important as lives" to justify the rejection of social distancing policies. Then, the government narrative became one of safeguarding people's individual freedoms against the tyranny of governors and mayors. At a military ceremony in December 2020, when Brazil reported 181,143 COVID-19 deaths, Bolsonaro declared: "When the state takes over individual interests and liberties, it rarely pulls back. Let us not allow panic to dominate us. Our freedom is priceless, it is worth more than our own lives" (Correio Braziliense 2020).

As soon as vaccines became available, the president began systematically playing the individual liberty card to deny mandatory immunization: "We cannot inject anything into people, let alone forcefully" (September 8, 127,517 deaths) (Estadão 2020). "Vaccines will not be compulsory. This individual [São Paulo governor João Doria] is terrorizing the public opinion" (October 19, 154,226 deaths) (CNN 2020a). "I, Jair Bolsonaro, am not against vaccines. But I'm totally favorable to the [hydroxychloroquine] treatment we have in Brazil. And I'll tell you: I'm not taking the vaccine, period. If anyone thinks my life is at risk, it's my problem, period" (December 15, 182,854 deaths) (Soares 2020). "There's no justification for rushing with vaccines, because you're dealing with people's lives" (December 19, 186,365 deaths and figures on the rise) (CNN 2020b).

Another anti-vax conspiracy theory advanced to sabotage Brazil's immunization efforts pictured China as the all-powerful nation who used COVID-19 to rule the world. Reproducing a very frequent talking point among President Trump and his supporters in the United States, the Bolsonaro administration claimed that the Chinese had spread the virus across the world for economic and geopolitical reasons. In an openly racist tweet, the then Education Minister mocked the Chinese accent and asked: "geopolitically, who will *lise stlonger*, in *lelative telms*, *flom* this world *clisis*?" (UOL Notícias 2020c). A few weeks later, in April 2020, the then Foreign Minister published an article called "Comunavirus" [sic] in his personal blog, denouncing a China-led plot to use the pandemic to implement a communoglobalist plan of world domination (Araújo 2020).

Although Bolsonaro himself have always been more careful to not openly antagonize China, he exploited the growing sinophobic sentiment among his political base to question the efficacy of the Chinese–Brazilian vaccine Coronavac, produced in a joint venture between the Chinese company Sinopharm and the São Paulo state agency Butantan Institute. Downplaying Coronavac—or Vac-China, as Bolsonaro calls it—was a means to undermine the efforts undertaken by his rival (Sao Paulo's governor) and delegitimize vaccination altogether. A few days after the São Paulo governor announced that the first doses of the

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vaccine would be available by early 2021, Bolsonaro declared to journalists: "Pfizer's contract is crystal clear: we will not be responsible for any side effects. If you turn into an alligator, it's your problem. If you become Superman, if women start growing a beard, or a man's voice gets higher, they have nothing to do with that. Or what's worse, [vaccines are] messing with people's immune system" (in Fernandes 2020).

Despite the president's contempt for vaccines, a survey published on January 23, 2021, by pollster Datafolha revealed that 79 percent of Brazilians wanted to be vaccinated.[6] Growing calls for a "return to normalcy"—especially after the former President Lula da Silva had his corruption convictions annulled by the Supreme Court and launched an informal presidential campaign with an eye on the 2022 race—forced the Bolsonaro administration to adapt its narrative to prevent further loss of popularity. Soon after Lula made a remarkable speech against Bolsonaro in mid-March, asking "where is Joe Droplet?" (the decades-long symbol of Brazil's federal immunization campaigns), the Brazilian healthcare mascot appeared in the social media of Eduardo Bolsonaro, the president's son and congressman. However, rather than showing his original children-friendly features, Joe Droplet was depicted holding a syringe in the shape of an M-16 assault rifle and wearing the Brazilian national flag (captured by the radical right as a political symbol) as a cape. "Now, our weapon is the vaccine," the lawmaker wrote in a rather cynical tone (in Silva de Souza 2021). On that day alone, 2,152 Brazilians had died from COVID-19, and the country had surpassed 275 thousand deaths in one year (CNN 2021).

## Conclusion

In this article, we explored links between cruelty and radical right populism. While we are not the first to do this, we innovated by discussing cruelty under a broad understanding, incorporating cruelty through indifference. We investigated the proposed intersection through an empirical case: the Brazilian president Jair Bolsonaro—who we categorize as an RRP—and his approach to COVID-19, which we consider to be a manifestation of cruelty by indifference.

Our first conclusion is that the study of cruelty should not be limited to a definition bounded by *pleasure* in the pain of others. The conscious disregard—even contempt—for other people's pain, particularly when manifested by those in a position of power to do something about the cause(s) of the distress, is also another example of cruelty. To be clear, we are not claiming that all political inaction or indifference fits of cruelty. Sometimes, these are simply a "normal" manifestation of leadership incompetence or lack of awareness reflecting a faulty advisory structure (e.g., echo chamber). What we do wish to highlight is how purposeful inaction and indifference should also be incorporated to reflections over cruelty. This bears significant importance for those interested in cruelty from a global perspective, as it helps to bring in a richer conversation over the topic and potentially recast the existing conversations under a new light. For example, deliberate political indifference toward climate change *is* cruelty—as is indifference toward racism, economic inequalities, refugees, etc. As such, cruelty is not something to be found only in nondemocratic regimes but can be easily witnessed in "civilized" nations when leaders choose to ignore pain. In terms of agenda setting, because cruelty is seen as a taboo, there is potentially more impact in naming-and-shaming certain cases of leadership indifference to pain as cruelty rather than incompetence (e.g., lack of clean water for First Nations people in Canada is not an example of incompetence but of cruelty). At the extreme, the risk here would be for everything to be placed under the "cruelty" label, at which point it would seek to have meaning, akin to claiming everything is "urgent." While we recognize the challenges attached to conceptual stretching, we still believe the study of cruelty in the global setting benefits from a *lato sensu* approach.

A second conclusion is that cruelty and (radical right) populism bear significant overlaps. Not all cruel leaders are populists, but it is valid to claim that cruelty and populists are frequent companions, particularly when the latter draw on an exclusionary ideology, as the radical right. Populism, due to its own inherent characteristics, provides a fertile ground for cruelty. For example, the binary societal division is entangled with the dehumanization of "the other." "Their" pain is not "the *people's* pain" and therefore is not (as) worthy of action or attention. In a democratic setting (even if fragile), there are usually legal limits to how much a populist leader can push such indifference to "the other" before this stance shifts from an ethical and moral—rather, *unethical* and *amoral*—issue and becomes a legal one, perhaps even criminal. In any case, populists' dichotomized worldview is ripe for manifestations of cruelty toward "the other," with this group being an empty vessel. In parallel, "bad manners" are an expected—even admired—facet of the populist style. Thus, even when cruel words are uttered that offend those who see themselves as part of "the people," a populist's followers are more likely to forgive or minimize what was said: "he means well," "I wouldn't use those words, but he has a point," "better than having a [corrupt, communist, neoliberal, immigrant, etc.] in power," etc. Finally, the sense of urgency and crisis, also typical of the populist style, can be used to justify cruel actions: "I don't want to do this [cruel thing], but if I don't do this *now* and *in this way*, the [enemy] will win and destroy us forever." Paradoxically, the same rationale of imminent danger can also be used to justify inaction and indifference: if the populist leader does not conceive of something as an imminent danger (and neither do its followers), paralysis and disregard are justified. For example, if one does not believe COVID-19 (or climate change, racism, xenophobia, etc.) is a "real" problem, there is no sense of urgency to act. All reports of pain—even if they include thousands of deaths—from the "fake" problem are recast as drama, exaggeration, statistical errors, political ploy, attention seeking, etc. Thus, standing still to a "fake" crisis is not cruel but rather *the* right thing to do.

Finally, the empirical case questions whether the concepts of "global south" and "global north" matter to discussions over cruelty and populism. While we did not explore a comparative analysis in this piece, it is important to point out that similarities and differences among populists are detached from this dichotomy. It is true that left-wing populists are more common in Latin America, but those studying President Bolsonaro's populism know that the substance of his right-wing populist discourse is much closer to that of Hungary's Prime Minister Viktor Orbán than neighboring Venezuela's Nicolas Maduro. Yet, regardless of where these leaders sit on the left–right spectrum, as populists, their overarching approaches to politics—and cruelty—carry the same rhythm and rhyme.

[6] This number grew to 94 percent in mid-July 2021.

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